

TENNESSEE VOICES

New lows in higher education

Cost of Tennessee bureaucracy detracts from teaching students

By Leonard Assante

As any citizen would be, I am deeply troubled by the financial crisis our state finds itself in.

As this paper has reported, state agencies are being asked to make significant, some say draconian, cutbacks. Among them is higher education, represented by the Tennessee Board of Regents, the University of Tennessee Board of Trustees and the Tennessee Higher Education Commission.

These three groups appear before a governor who has had great vision in so many areas, but yet seems so myopic on this issue. The message the boards have for the governor is disappointing, and the governor's response is disappointing. To get out of the current mess, and to set in place the groundwork to avoid future crisis requires a plan significantly different and bolder than the boards are putting forth and better leadership on the part of the governor, whose single-minded focus on across-the-board cuts is helping no one, certainly not the students the systems are supposed to serve.

The staff at the Board of Regents has put forth a series of ideas that will frame the debate on funding cuts at the system level. These ideas focus almost entirely at the place where the rubber meets the road:



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interaction between faculty and students. They make but one vague mention of structural changes, leaving most of the pain to be borne by the faculty and the students.

Clearly, we need better than that, and we need a plan that saves higher education, not decimates it. We need to restructure higher education in Tennessee to create a more efficient and less duplicative administrative structure. First, we must create community-college districts (East, Middle, West) with district presidents, vice presidents and directors of human resources, purchasing, accounting and so forth, while eliminating these functions at the individual colleges. Savings in salary and benefits of more than \$7 million per year will result. California uses this model and has the lowest community-college tuition in the nation and a much higher percentage of citizens with college degrees.

THEC an unnecessary layer

Next, eliminate THEC. THEC does two relatively unimportant things: It ensures TBR and UT don't overlap programs, and it regulates proprietary schools. The first function can be accomplished by legislative fiat; the second can be folded into the Education Department. Offer buyouts or retirement to employees affected by the first two steps.

We then must examine college administrative structures. Many are still quite "ver-



Austin Peay State University graduates hold their degrees during commencement. BETH LIGGETT COGBILL / FILE / GANNETT TENNESSEE

tical," with administrators who do things outside the core mission of the colleges. Some are called vice presidents (and paid accordingly) while having few direct reports. Finally, if we want to get really serious, we should consider combining UT and TBR or folding the community colleges into the administrative structure of the universities, reducing even more overhead and allowing more money to be spent on educating students.

The goal of TBR seems to be to keep the structure the same and force the pain down the ranks, to faculty and students.

The governor seems focused on across-the-board cuts, rather than an examination of the core processes of state government. This is a painful and shortsighted method of budget cuts.

Just ask the Detroit automakers. Cutting service to students only reduces our tax base in the long run, which only makes our current problem worse. We have a new majority in the legislature wanting to make a mark and a budget crisis that cries out for bold thinking. The time to act is now.

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Hard work, shared values brought GOP victories

By Robin Smith

On election night, voters spoke loudly with the echoes reverberating still today.

In Tennessee, Sen. John McCain carried the state with 57 percent of the vote, Sen. Lamar Alexander was re-elected with 65 percent, and 14 new Republican legislators were elected, yielding a Republican majority in the General Assembly for the first time since 1868.

Voters elected legislators who carried the same values and principles that are held by average citizens in these districts. Those val-



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ues and principles are pretty simple. Taxes and spending: The government should live within its means and oppose higher tax bills to fund a bloated budget; the voters know government needs to cut spending. Gun rights: Voters want common-sense carry laws, making it easier for them to protect themselves and their families. Local economies: Families in their community know that improvements are needed by investing in transportation and education infrastructure to support existing jobs and recruit new businesses. They are tired of the power brokers in Nashville increasing entitlement programs instead.

Candidates who displayed the courage to challenge Democratic

incumbents and in open seats were solid, qualified individuals. They were not just "known" in their communities. They are people who truly represent the values of their communities. We believe this is what our founders intended with citizen legislators. The hard work and time commitment that is necessary to run campaigns are a good test of how hard each legislator will work for his or her district. The people of these districts will be well-represented by their new representatives' principled leadership.

Volunteers across Tennessee were tremendously diligent in their efforts. The grass-roots volunteers who made phone calls into neighboring districts, raising

money to pay for local newspaper ads and canvassing neighborhoods were just a few of the efforts that yielded victories in legislative districts, many that have been Democratic strongholds for decades.

Limited government

The message from the candidates never strayed from the very DNA of our Tennessee Republican Party: an emphasis on a limited, accountable, yet effective government with the wealth and opportunity for individuals all wrapped in our constitutional values — life and liberty.

So the ingredients for Tennessee's successful election were the

standard nuts and bolts of our campaigns combined with the irreplaceable enthusiasm of volunteers and voters for our candidates. The election night victories resulted from great candidates, great volunteers, proper funding, a consistent, conviction-based message and a strategy that was implemented, rather than on a shelf gathering dust.

Now, these new members join Republican majorities and face the most difficult task of all: governing at the level of dignity and decorum the people of Tennessee deserve. Tennesseans have put their trust in us, and our leaders will deliver.

Robin Smith is chairman of the Tennessee Republican Party.

OPINION

Senate seats aren't Kennedys' by royal decree

Have New York Democrats lost all self-respect?

Their excited talk of whether Caroline Kennedy is "interested" in Hillary Clinton's Senate seat makes you wonder. The late John F. Kennedy's daughter has made at least one feeler phone call to New York Gov. David Paterson. And Uncle Teddy, the Massachusetts senator, is busy pulling the levers to slip her in. The seat will be vacant upon Clinton's confirmation as secretary of state.

This unsavory spectacle has been upstaged by the wild drama in Illinois, where Gov. Rod Blagojevich is being accused of trying to sell Barack Obama's Senate seat. The doings in New York are not blatant corruption, but they are corrosive to our democratic ideals. Lest anyone forget the point of the American Revolution, our representatives are not chosen by hereditary succession, which, to quote Thomas Paine, "is an insult and imposition on pos-



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terity."

Of course, Caroline can ask for whatever she wants. The astounding part is that the idea of such a request hasn't been laughed out of the news pages.

New York Mayor Michael Bloomberg, against all evidence, touts Caroline as "a very experienced woman." Her government service starts and ends at raising private money for the New York City schools. While a worthy endeavor, it's a socialite's job.

For nearly four decades after her father's assassination, Caroline commendably resisted the

call to become a Democratic Party ornament. Then at the 2000 Democratic convention, she stepped on the stage to the tune of *Camelot* and, with no little presumption, thanked the American people for "sustaining us through the good times, and the difficult ones, and for helping us dream my father's dream." Then, she introduced "Uncle Teddy."

Women's groups have been eager to see Clinton replaced by another female. The Feminist Majority and the National Organization for Women had already endorsed Carolyn Maloney, a congresswoman who has represented parts of Manhattan and Queens for 15 years.

But if Caroline Kennedy wants the job, all bets are off, according to Feminist Majority President Eleanor Smeal. "You're talking to someone who thinks Ted Kennedy is the most effective senator there," Smeal actually told *The New York Times*.

Here you have it. Without a second thought, feminists talk of throwing a seasoned, self-made professional overboard to make room for a Kennedy princess.

Uncle Ted has been reminding Democrats that Caroline would be backed by — as the *Times* straightforwardly put it — "the Kennedy family's extensive fundraising network." That's nice, but this is New York state, where electing a Democrat requires no miracle.

Set aside whether any seat should be gender-specific. It certainly shouldn't be genealogy-specific. But that's one of Caroline's selling points, at least from the Kennedy perspective.

The seat was held for three years by her uncle Robert F. Kennedy, who was killed in 1968. For this reason, RFK's son Robert F. Kennedy Jr. was also eyeing the seat for himself. (Perhaps he could be made ambassador to France, instead.)

Hey, what about the Moynihans? Democrat Daniel Patrick Moynihan occupied that Senate chair for more than 20 years. No Moynihan has yet come forward to claim it as a family possession to be handed down unto the generations.

Are we really having this conversation?

Paterson says he hasn't decided whom he will choose, though he notes that Caroline is "thinking about" the Senate position. According to the *Times*, "Some influential Democrats have privately suggested that given the buzz set off by Ms. Kennedy's emergence, the governor would have little choice but to appoint her if she decided she truly wanted the job."

Actually, he does have a choice. Can New York Democrats summon up some dignity? We shall see.

Froma Harrop is a syndicated columnist. For information, visit www.creators.com.

History proves instructive on quality of Illinois graft

The response of Kathryn Jean Lopez (National Review Online) to the arrest of Rod Blagojevich was priceless.

"Finally, a political scandal you can talk to your children about. No room at the Mayflower. No MySpace page. No gay-American announcement. Just good and evil and money and power corrupting." Rod Blagojevich is part of a storied American tradition. By selling government posts, shaking down businesses that had dealings with the state, and maneuvering to get lucrative jobs for his wife and himself, Blagojevich was practicing "honest graft."

The distinction between "honest graft" and "dishonest graft" was elucidated by a turn-of-the-century politico named George Washington Plunkitt, a Tammany Hall man. Tammany was the political machine that ran New York, then a lot like Illinois is today. "Everybody is talkin' these days about Tammany men growin' rich on graft, but nobody thinks of drawin' the distinction between honest graft and dishonest graft ... Yes, many of our men have grown rich in politics ... I've



>> MONA CHAREN

made a big fortune out of the game ... but I've not gone in for dishonest graft — blackmailin' gamblers, saloon-keepers, disorderly people, etc."

No, he explained, here's how "honest graft" works: "Well, I'm tipped off, say, that they're going to lay out a new park at a certain place. I see my opportunity and I take it. I go to that place and I buy up all the land I can in the neighborhood. Then the board of this or that makes its plan public, and there is a rush to get my land, which nobody cared particular for before. Ain't it perfectly honest to charge a good price and make a profit on my investment and foresight? ... Well, that's honest graft."

That was how things were

managed in the early 1900s. How is it done today? Blagojevich, who had authority to appoint a successor to the U.S. Senate seat vacated by Barack Obama, instructs his aide that "The trick is ... how do you conduct indirectly ... a negotiation?" Actually, on the evidence of these secretly taped conversations, Blagojevich was anything but indirect. "We were approached 'pay to play,'" he told an aide on Dec. 4. "That, you know, he'd raise me 500 grand. An emissary came. Then the other guy would raise a million if I made (Candidate 5) a senator."

Seeing himself in possession of a valuable commodity, Blagojevich wasn't about to give it away for mere gratitude. "It's not coming for free. ... I've got this thing and it's (expletive) golden, and, uh, uh, I'm just not giving it up for (expletive) nothing. I'm not gonna do it." At another point, he was subtly itself: "I want to make money."

Plunkitt had some other reflections on public service. He noted that "What tells in holdin' your grip on your district is to go right down among the poor families



and help them in the different ways they need help ... If there's a fire in Ninth, Tenth, or Eleventh Avenue, for example, any hour of the day or night, I'm usually there with some of my election district captains as soon as the fire engines. If a family is burned out I don't ask whether they are Republicans or Democrats, and I don't refer them to the Charity Organization Society ... I just get quarters for them, buy clothes for them ... and fix them up till they

get things runnin' again. It's philanthropy, but it's politics, too ... Who can tell how many votes one of these fires bring me? The poor are the most grateful people in the world and, let me tell you, they have more friends in their neighborhoods than the rich have in theirs."

On second thought, Blagojevich wouldn't be fit to shine Plunkitt's shoes.

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